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Neumann NDH 30

Exquisite open sound and stellar design

Neumann has had a long-standing reputation for delivering some of the best studio microphones and professional monitors in the business, and their NDH 30 attempts to honour that. Unlike its closed-back predecessor, the Neumann NDH 30 is an open-back, circumaural pair of studio headphones primarily targeting broadcast and music producers. These reference studio cans can be used for editing, mixing, and mastering purposes. Priced at ₹52,900, these cans are sure to put a dent in your wallet, but are they worth their asking price? Let's find out.

BUILD AND FEATURES

The Neumann NDH 30 bears a lot of resemblance to the NDH 20. One major difference is the open-back ear cups. These are wired studio monitor headphones with a brushed silver design with matte black accents. The headphones look and feel premium, primarily due to the high-quality materials used in their construction – namely aluminium and stainless steel mixed with a bit of plastic. The insides of the ear cups are coloured orange, which gives the cans a bit more flair in the design department. The headphones are pretty heavy at 350 grams but Neumann has done a commendable job with the weight distribution, so they don't feel uncomfortable despite their heft. The ear cups' pads are made of a velour-like material which the company calls "cloth-covered foam". They are supple, plushy and extremely comfortable, and also, swappable! The headband's cushioning is plushy as well. The cups are well ventilated due to the open-back design of the headphones but this does mean that sound leaks out considerably and there's not much passive isolation too. These are best for use in an indoor studio environment. The cans are fairly portable as well; the arms can be folded inwards and the cups rotate 90 degrees.



Neumann has also provided a cloth carrying bag but we expected a hard case at this price point. The headband is adjustable via a spring steel band and a perforated black metal grille protects the diaphragms inside. The clamping force is adequate. The cable attaches to the right side of the headphones; not the usual left side, so the cable could be in your way. Since these are wired, studio headphones, they don't have much in the way of features. They are studio reference monitors meant to be used inside a professional setup and features like water resistance, don't usually make their way onto professional gear.

PERFORMANCE

The Neumann NDH 30 mean serious business, and for ₹52,900, we expected nothing less from this reputed company. The sound profile is neutral with almost no colouration whatsoever, which is what you'd want from a professional reference-level pair of headphones. They pack 38 mm drivers that sit at a slight angle to replicate the monitors' directionality in a studio. They have an impedance of 120 ohms, so most devices, including some smart-

phones, should be able to power these alright without the need for a super powerful amp. The bass response is deep and bouncy, the mids are exceptionally balanced and detailed and the highs are dynamic and sparkly. The average consumer would maybe find the highs a tad harsh since these aren't coloured like consumer-grade headphones. Distortion is near non-existent even at high volume levels and the two drivers are balanced quite well too.

The open-back design allows for an open and spacious sound that cannot really be achieved by closed-back headphones such as the NDH 20. While passive isolation does suffer, the stage is vast which makes the listening experience very immersive. Due to the uncoloured sonic representation, you may feel the need to turn up the volume levels at times.

The NDH 30 matches up pretty well with the Sennheiser HD 660 S with an open, spacious and neutral sound.

VERDICT

The Neumann NDH 30 is an ideal open-back alternative to the popular NDH 20.

Of course, it is far costlier but what you get is an analytical, neutral sound profile that is perfect for mixing, mastering, and editing. They are exquisitely built, feel quite robust, and look premium. However, there are cheaper open-back headphones out there such as the Sennheiser HD 660 S and the Beyerdynamic DT 900 Pro X. But if price is no bar for you, the Neumann NDH 30 definitely won't disappoint, and are an all-around great investment.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

FREQUENCY RANGE: 12 - 34,000 Hz | ACOUSTIC PRINCIPLE: Dynamic open | EAR COUPLING: Circumaural/Over-ear | TRANSDUCER DIAMETER: 38 mm | NOMINAL IMPEDANCE: 120 Ohms | SENSITIVITY AT 1 KHZ/1 VRMS: 104 dB SPL | CONNECTIVITY: 3.5 mm (1/8") TRS jack plug (straight), adapter for 6.3 mm (1/4") | CABLE LENGTH: 3.0 m | WEIGHT EXCLUDING CABLE: 352 g

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